

Day 2 — The Vedic Corpus: Close Reading

Module: What is IKS? (Senior) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students read Ṛg Veda 1.1 and Īśa Upaniṣad opening in IAST with word-by-word gloss, and articulate the difference in tone between the two textual layers.

Materials

- Printed handout: Ṛg Veda 1.1 (Sanskrit + IAST + Jamison-Brereton translation)
- Printed handout: Īśa Upaniṣad opening verse (Sanskrit + IAST + Olivelle translation)

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

Recall: what are the four textual layers of the Veda? (Saṃhitā → Brāhmaṇa → Āraṇyaka → Upaniṣad.)

Reading 1: Ṛg Veda 1.1 (15 min)

agnim īle purohitam yajñasya devam ṛtvijam hotāraṃ ratnadhātām “I praise Agni, the household priest, the divine officiant of the sacrifice, the invoker, who is the best bestower of treasures.”

- Word-by-word: *agnim* (Agni, acc.) + *īle* (I praise) + *purohitam* (household priest) + *yajñasya* (of the sacrifice, gen.) ...
- **Note:** this is a hymn of praise. The earliest layer of the Veda is ritual-centric.
- The intellectual contribution at this layer: precise oral transmission (across ~3000 years) generated the linguistic discipline that became Pāṇini.

Reading 2: Īśa Upaniṣad opening (15 min)

īśā vāsyam idam sarvaṃ yat kiñca jagatyām jagat tena tyaktena bhuñjīthā mā grdhaḥ kasya svid dhanam “Whatever moves in this moving world is enveloped by the Lord. Enjoy what has been abandoned. Do not covet anyone’s wealth.”

- Word-by-word: *īśā* (by the Lord, inst.) + *vāsyam* (to be enveloped) + *idam sarvaṃ* (all this) ...
- **Note the move.** From ritual hymn (Saṃhitā) to ethical-philosophical reflection (Upaniṣad).
- The intellectual contribution at this layer: abstract metaphysical inquiry; the seed of Vedānta philosophy.

Discussion (5 min)

- Compare: the tone of the Agni hymn versus the Īśa Upaniṣad. What changed?

- The Vedic corpus contains BOTH — ritual and philosophy, hymn and abstract reflection. “Vedic” is a span, not a single voice.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Preview Day 3: “*Tomorrow — the six darśanas, the philosophical schools.*”

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Read 5 more verses of Īśa Upaniṣad. Identify one verse that surprised you.
- **Tier down:** Focus on the contrast between the two readings, not detailed Sanskrit.

Teacher notes

- Pronunciation perfection is NOT the goal. Engagement with meaning is.
- Some students will notice that the Upanishadic voice sounds “more modern philosophical.” That’s a real observation worth honouring.

Citation(s) used

- Jamison & Brereton (2014) for Ṛg Veda 1.1.
- Olivelle (1996) for Īśa Upaniṣad.